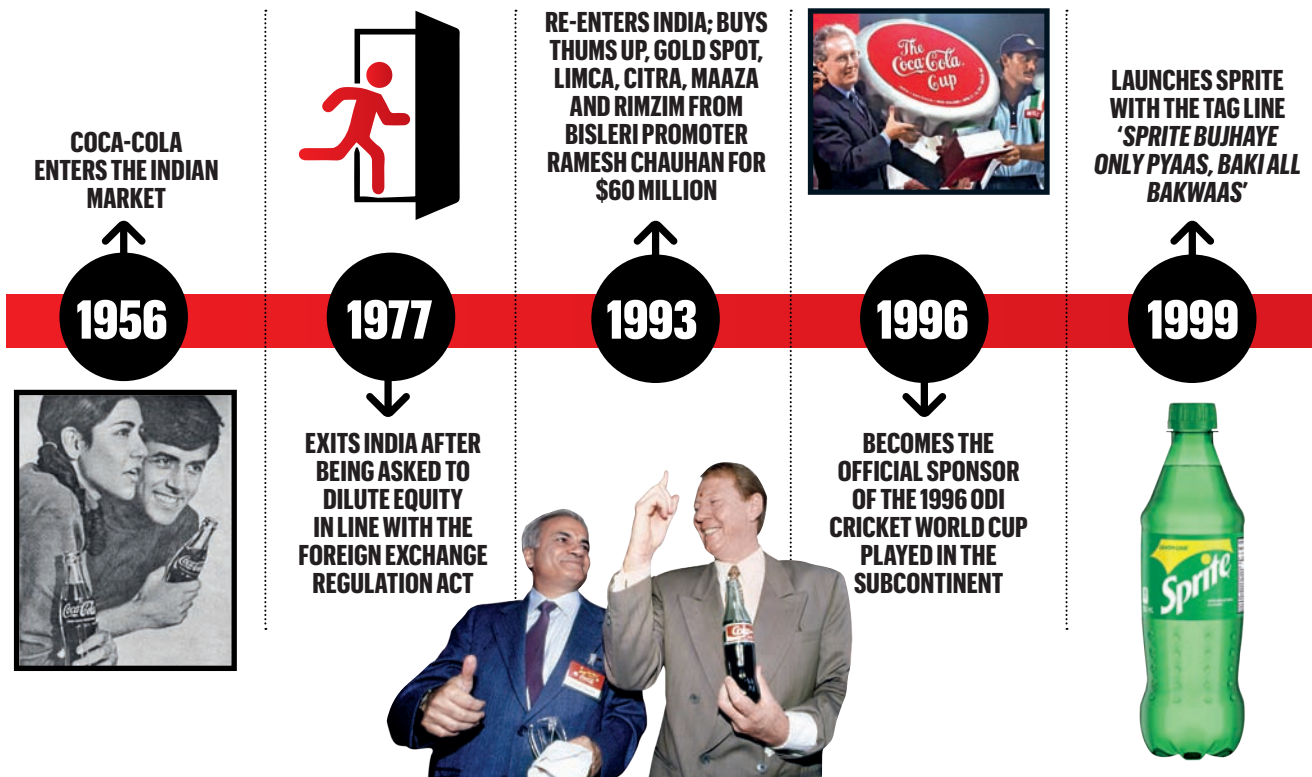




Up Charged was relaunched as just Charged (with only a logo of Thums Up), and Coke officials say it is today the market leader in the same three states. “We have had some success, but Sting is a national brand and Charged sells in only four-five states,” points out Roy. “Our bottlers need to be convinced; once that happens, we will be present in more parts of India.”

Thums Up, as well as mother brand Coke, might also face some headwinds from the re-entry of Campa Cola, which was recently acquired by Reliance Industries. Pointing out that Campa Cola was at its peak when Coca-Cola and Pepsi were not present in India, Narayanan feels the brand, which has nostalgic value, might get a boost from its new owners: “It will get distribution in all their online and offline stores. This is a big positive.” But he adds that those who remember the brand are older and not the biggest consuming class for aerated drinks, and so it is likely to have limited appeal.

Another challenge for Coca-Cola is in packaged water, where Kinley slugs it out against, literally, thousands of players. “The business has a long tail and is price-sensitive,” explains Roy. Still, the company will need to have a presence since water gives it entry into

retail outlets. “It is a minus point in summer if your brand is not visible.” Here it is up against market leader Bisleri, which has a 32 per cent share of the organised market, according to industry officials quoting Nielsen numbers, with Kinley and PepsiCo’s Aquafina trailing it. Bisleri had an operating revenue of ₹1,133 crore in Covid-hit FY21 (it was at ₹1,465 crore in FY20)—with at least 90 per cent of that coming from water—and a net profit of ₹95 crore.

Half-jokingly, Bisleri International’s Chairman Ramesh Chauhan says success in the packaged water business is a combination of emotion and dedication. “You have to deal with high volumes and low margins. Since water is a commodity, building a brand is not easy,” he explains. Bisleri derives a big chunk of its revenue from the bulk segment—the large plastic cans visible in offices.



THE INDIA STORY has proved handy in neighbouring markets. For instance, high inflation in Sri Lanka saw the